

set timeline, and rationed resources, showed high levels of motivation, creativity, and ability to connect information and bring about innovative solutions. Alternatively, when people were given no constraints on budget or time, the output revealed very little ingenuity or effort.

The same is true for you! Parameters, limitations, and constraints provide the context to create. Your income, family, education level, and living situation don't need to be viewed as hindrances to the way you want to spend. Instead, they can be the things that inform *how* you spend. They are the guidelines for your creativity and help to define how you can have the things you love within the realities of your situation. And even the things you want to change in order to have more of what you love.

For me (Jill), in my debt payoff endeavor, I often felt frustrated by the limitations of my season. Being new in my career, saddled with student loan debt, and only making a meager salary had me wishing I could skip ahead a few years to when I imagined things would be better. Ultimately, it took me and my husband, Eric, seven years to pay off \$60,000 of debt. Those numbers are not remarkable. That time-to-money ratio isn't newsworthy. *But* over the course of those seven years, we did become debt free! In a time when our annual household income fluctuated between \$45,000 and \$60,000, we couldn't be the people who paid everything off in a matter of months. While our story will never be the title of some clickbait-y article, we still ended it debt-free.

In the very beginning of paying down our debt, I had hopes of getting rid of all of it in five years. But as time went on, I realized it was going to take a bit longer. It didn't feel great, but recognizing our limitations and the realities of our season allowed us to embrace a new, extended timeline for debt payoff. So much happened in those years. Eric changed careers, I switched jobs (a few times), we moved nearly every year, and I got my master's degree. Some of those circumstances gave us an opportunity to throw chunks of money toward our debt, and at other times we needed to reel it in and simply focus on covering our living expenses.

While there were certainly disappointments and moments of impatience throughout the journey, I can say without doubt that I have no regrets. As I look back now, I don't wish that we had broken our backs to pay it off quicker. Life was lived in those seven years, and little by little the debt dwindled. It's what those seasons of life allowed for, and working within my reality, rather than against it, made all the difference for me. It didn't